

How to play games with Ozmoo

Introduction

This manual explains how to play Ozmoo games, and how to use special features such as RAM expansions and darkmode. Since Ozmoo is using direct access to floppy discs or floppy images, there are also some differences to be aware of when it comes to copying games, saving and restoring saves, and handling large games.

Starting a game

To start the game, just insert the floppy in the floppy drive and type `load "story",8` and `run`. On Plus/4 and C128, you can also use `dload "story"` and then `run`.

Playing a game

Type commands in plain English each time you see the prompt (`>`). Most of the sentences that games will understand are imperative sentences, as if you are commanding the computer to do things. When you have finished typing your input, press the RETURN (or ENTER) key, and the game will then respond, telling you whether your request is possible at this point in the story, and what happened as a result.

You can include several inputs on one line if you separate them by the word “then” or by a period. Each input will be handled in order, as though you had typed them individually at separate prompts. If the game doesn’t understand one of the sentences on your input line, or if an unusual event occurs, it will ignore the rest of your input line.

To move around, just type the direction you want to go. In addition to the compass directions, “up”, “down”, “in” and “out” can also work in some places. Aboard a ship, you may be able to use “fore”, “aft”, “starboard” and “port”.

There are many different kinds of sentences used in interactive fiction games. Here are some examples:

>north

>w

>down

>take the sword

>examine the dirty towel

>put the shiny key in the wooden box

You can use multiple objects with certain verbs (usually “take”, “drop”, “put” and “insert”) if you separate them by the word “and” or by a comma. Some examples:

>take the book and the ladder

>drop the pink book, the torch and the key

The word “it” and other pronouns can be handy. For example:

>examine the apple. take it. eat it

The word “all” refers to every visible object except those inside something else. If there were an apple on the ground and an orange inside a cabinet, “take all” would take the apple but not the orange. “take all from the cabinet” on the other hand, would of course take the orange.

When you meet intelligent creatures, you can talk to them by typing their name, then a comma, then whatever you want to say to them or ask them to do. For example:

>Lisa, hello

>John, open the box

Darkmode

Ozmoo games can toggle between normal colours and a dark mode. This is done by pushing the F1 key whenever the game is waiting for input. The colours used by normal and dark mode are decided by the game author.

Scrolling slowness / Smooth scrolling

You can choose how fast text scrolling is, by pressing one of these keys while the game is waiting for input.

- Ctrl-0: Make scrolling as fast as possible
- Ctrl-1 .. Ctrl-8: Make scrolling gradually slower, while making sure the scrolling is flicker-free and tear-free (= looks better) (*)
- Ctrl-9: Enable smooth scrolling, if available (scroll text one pixel at a time)

Mode Ctrl-9 is default if available, otherwise mode Ctrl-1 is default.

(*) On C128 in 80 column mode, Ozmoos can't guarantee flicker-free and tear-free scrolling

Saving

The “save” commands creates a snapshot of your current position. You can return to a saved position in the future by using the “restore” command. When you use “save” or “restore” you will be asked to insert a save disk. If your game disk is a 1581 floppy disk (or a .d81 floppy image) then you can safely use it as a save disk as well, otherwise you will need to prepare an empty floppy disk or a disk image (d64, d71 or d81) to use as a save disk. Do not store other files on this disk, and do not use the same disk as a save disk for several games!

Once you have saved or restored the game the first time during a play session, Ozmoos will remember the save device you chose and won't ask again. If you want to change the save device, press Ctrl-D, and you'll be asked to input the save device next time you save or restore.

Large games

Ozmoos has several build modes to allow even large game files to be played, which may require more than one floppy disk. Small games fit on one floppy (called the Boot / Story disk), while large games have one Boot disk and one Story disk. You start the game from the Boot disk, and then change to the Story disk when prompted.

However, really large games may use two Story disks. Such games can only be played if you have either two floppy drives, or a ram expansion unit (REU).

Graphical games

Four Infocom games - Arthur, Journey, Shogun and Zork Zero - draw pictures as well as text. Ozmoos plays all four on every computer it supports, but only the MEGA65 and the Commander X16 have the video hardware to draw the pictures.

On the Commodore 64, the 128 and the Plus/4 you can play these games from beginning to end, but where a picture belongs you will see a short note instead, such as `pic:12`. This is not a fault: it is Ozmoos telling you a picture would have been there, and keeping the rest of the screen in its proper shape.

On the MEGA65 each of the four games is a single disk: the pictures are packed small enough to share it with the game itself. Start it and the pictures load by themselves, under a “loading graphics” line — there is nothing to insert, and no second drive is needed. (Should a picture set ever be too big to share a disk, it gets a picture disk of its own, and Ozmoos asks for it: `insert picture disk 1`, and you change disks and press a key. None of these four games needs that.)

Arthur and Zork Zero can also be played with a mouse on the MEGA65: plug a 1351 or Amiga mouse into control port 2, and a pointer appears. Zork Zero’s on-screen controls can be clicked, and Arthur lets you click to dismiss a [MORE] prompt.

On the Commander X16 the pictures are ordinary files that live beside the game, and it reads each one from the SD card as it draws it, so keep them together when you copy the game.

Copying

An Ozmoos game stores data directly onto the floppy disk in addition to files. Because of this, it is not possible to copy a game to a new floppy by just copying files. If you want to make a copy you need to use a copy program that copies the whole disk, sectors by sector.

Ozmoos and REUs

Ozmoos for C64 and C128 can use a RAM expansion unit (REU). This is what happens when the game starts, if an REU is detected:

- Ozmoos asks if you want to use the REU for faster play. If you answer Yes, space is reserved for caching the entire game in the REU. This reserves 1-8 64 KB banks in the REU.
- If Ozmoos was built with Undo support, and there’s a free 64 KB bank in the REU, one such bank is reserved for Undo.
- If Ozmoos was built with Scrollback support, and there’s a free 64 KB bank in the REU, one such bank is reserved for Scrollback.

Additionally, an REU can be used instead of a second floppy drive when playing very large games that would otherwise need dual floppy drives, as described in the “Large games” section above.

Using an REU for faster gameplay

Ozmoo for C64 and C128 can use an REU to cache story data. This makes gameplay faster, but the game will take longer to start.

If Ozmoo detects an REU at startup, and it's big enough to hold all game data, Ozmoo will ask if you want to use the REU for faster play. If the REU is 512 KB or more, any game will fit.

Undo

Ozmoo can be built with support for Undo, meaning the player can revert the effects of their last move in a game. This feature is available on the MEGA65, The Commander X16, the C64 with an REU and the C128 with or without an REU. If the game uses Z-code version 5 or higher, the game needs to provide an UNDO command (which most version 5+ games do). For version 1-4, Ozmoo provides Ctrl-U as a hotkey to perform undo - this can be pressed at a text prompt only. If no REU is detected, or there's no room for an undo buffer in the REU, and Ozmoo wasn't built with support for undo in RAM (C128 only), Ozmoo will print a message saying undo is not available.

If Ozmoo was built with this feature, the splash screen will mention the undo feature.

Scrollback buffer

Ozmoo has an optional feature called Scrollback buffer, which can be used on all platforms except Commander X16, and in all games except the graphical version 6 ones (whose several windows each scroll their own part of the screen). With the Scrollback buffer feature enabled, you can press F5 at any input prompt or More prompt, to access the text the game has printed this far. Use F5/F7 as PageUp/PageDown, and Enter to exit scrollback mode.

On the C64 and C128, scrollback can either be built to work with an REU only, or it can reserve a buffer in RAM as well. On the MEGA65 and Plus/4, it always uses a RAM buffer. If Ozmoo was built to work only with an REU, and no REU is detected, or there is no room for a scrollback buffer in the REU, Ozmoo will print a message saying scrollback isn't available.

If Ozmoo was built with this feature, the splash screen will say "F5=Scrollback".

Patched games

Ozmoo has a list of known game files which it can patch on the fly while bundling the game with Ozmoo.

Beyond Zork

Ozmoo has support for Beyond Zork, which was never released on the Commodore 64. Beyond Zork was designed for 80 column screens, and to make it playable Ozmoo makes minor modifications to fit all information on a 40 column screen. The map and screen decorations are using simplified ASCII characters, and Darkmode is disabled since Beyond Zork requires control over the colours. The title screen hasn't been modified, so it shows text that doesn't quite fit on a 40 column screen.

Trinity

Trinity will normally check that the screen is wide enough (60+ characters) and if it's not, print a message and exit the game. Ozmoo will automatically patch the game to remove this check.

Varicella

Varicella has a monochrome mode, a limited colour mode and a full colour mode. The full colour mode does some tricks which would confuse Ozmoo. For this reason, Ozmoo patches Varicella to make the full colour mode work well even on Ozmoo.